VULNERABILITY TRIAGE REPORT

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Scope: Triage of 7 scan findings for an organisation's environment

Method: Risk-based prioritisation (severity weighed by exposure, value, active exploitation, patchability)

1. SUMMARY

Seven scan findings were prioritised by real risk rather than raw severity. The top priority is Finding 1, the actively exploited, internet-facing web framework vulnerability on the public company website, because it is being attacked right now and a patch is already available. The unpatchable, internet-facing legacy system (Finding 6) is second and is handled with compensating controls, and the critical finding in software the organisation does not run (Finding 3) is dropped as having no real risk.

2. FINDINGS AND REAL-RISK ASSESSMENT

#	Severity	Real risk	Key factors
1	CRITICAL	HIGH	Public website; actively exploited; patch available.
2	HIGH	MEDIUM	Internal customer DB server; not internet-facing; high value; no exploitation; patch available.
3	CRITICAL	NONE/LOW	Software not installed anywhere; nothing to exploit.
4	MEDIUM	LOW	Isolated test machine; no valuable data; no external access; patch available.
5	HIGH	HIGH	Finance laptops; sensitive financial files; reached via phishing/web; no known exploitation; patch available.
6	CRITICAL	HIGH	Legacy system; internet-facing; unsupported, cannot be patched; compensating controls possible.
7	LOW	LOW	Public website; minor information disclosure only; patch available.

Justifications

1. **HIGH:** Critical flaw on an internet-facing system that attackers are exploiting in the wild, with a fix ready: highest exposure plus active exploitation.
2. **MEDIUM:** The system is very valuable (customer database) and the severity is high, but it is not directly internet-facing, has other defences in front of it, and is not being exploited, so the likelihood is lower.
3. **NONE/LOW:** The software is not installed anywhere, so there is nothing to exploit; this is a scanner false positive or a stale flag, regardless of its CRITICAL label.
4. **LOW:** A medium flaw on a machine with no valuable data and no external access means very little can be reached or lost.

5. **HIGH:** Sensitive financial data on machines that read email and browse the web (the usual route in via phishing), so exposure and value are both significant even without known exploitation.
6. **HIGH:** A critical flaw on an internet-facing system that can never be patched is a permanent open door, so it stays high risk until it is isolated or retired.
7. **LOW:** Minor information disclosure only, so impact is small, although its public exposure and easy fix put it above the isolated test machine.

3. PRIORITISED FIX-FIRST ORDER

Order	Finding	Why
1st	Finding 1	Actively exploited, internet-facing, and the patch is ready. The clearest "fix right now": emergency patch.
2nd	Finding 6	Internet-facing and critical, but it cannot be patched, so the work is compensating controls started immediately (isolate, restrict, monitor).
3rd	Finding 5	Sensitive finance data on laptops that are exposed to phishing and web threats.
4th	Finding 2	High-value customer database server, but protected by other layers and not exploited.
5th	Finding 7	Low impact, but public-facing and an easy patch.
6th	Finding 4	Isolated test machine with nothing of value.
Drop	Finding 3	The software is not installed, so there is no real risk and no patching work is needed.

4. TRADE-OFFS AND DEFERRED RISK

Consciously deferred

Findings 2, 4 and 7 are scheduled for later patch cycles, and Finding 3 is dropped. By deferring Finding 2, we accept a short window in which the customer database server still carries a high-severity OS flaw. We accept this because it is not internet-facing, has other defences in front of it, and is not being exploited; the risk is reduced but not removed.

Compensating controls (for what can't be patched now): the legacy system (Finding 6)

- Isolate it on a separate network segment (DMZ-style) so a compromise cannot reach internal systems such as the customer database.
- Restrict inbound access to only the ports and source addresses genuinely needed; disable unused services.
- Place it behind a web application firewall or intrusion prevention system that can block known exploit attempts (virtual patching).

Would re-prioritise if

- Exploitation of any deferred vulnerability (especially Finding 2 or 5) is reported in the wild, or a public exploit is released; it would then move up immediately.
- Finding 6 shows signs of attack or a working exploit appears, which would escalate it to emergency status.
- The software in Finding 3 turns out to be installed somewhere, in which case it must be reassessed.

5. REASONING APPROACH

Severity (the CVSS rating) was the starting point, not the answer. Each finding was then weighed by exposure (can attackers reach it?), value (how critical is the system or data?), active exploitation (is it being attacked now?), and patch availability (can it be fixed, or does it need compensating controls?). This changes the picture a lot: a CRITICAL finding in software that is not installed ranks last, a MEDIUM finding on an isolated test machine is lower risk than a LOW finding on the public website, and a critical unpatchable system is handled with controls instead of waiting for a patch. The key insight is that severity is not the same as real risk; real risk is severity weighed by context.